

Battle of Long Tan

The 60,000 Australians who fought alongside US and ARVN troops in the war displayed resilience and courage in many operations. Nowhere was this more true than at Long Tan, where they were victorious despite being outnumbered twenty to one.

◀◀ BEFORE

Over time, Australia's advisory role in Vietnam changed to direct combat.

JUNGLE BASE

In 1962, the Australian government sent 30 military advisers to South Vietnam. Three years later it sent a battalion, which would operate under American command. In 1966, the **First Australian Task Force** (1ATF), an independent unit of 4,500 men, was sent to **Phuoc Tuy province**, southeast of Saigon, an area covered in dense vegetation, with a long tradition of resistance to foreigners.

The First Australian Task Force's (1ATF) mission in Vietnam was to win control of Phuoc Tuy province. The bulk of 1ATF was made up of two infantry battalions, a squadron of armored personnel carriers (APCs), and two artillery batteries. They were joined by a New Zealand artillery battery that had been in Vietnam since 1965, and supported by US artillery and air support.

In June 1966, 1ATF established a base at Nui Dat, in the center of the province. They improved the village defenses and mounted a series of patrols, without major engagements. On July 29, however, Australian intelligence discovered a large force of Viet Cong and NVA troops, totaling some 2,500 men, in the surrounding area. The communists' mission was to show their strength to the local villagers by striking at the Australians and perhaps overrunning the base. Hanoi believed that a defeat of 1ATF would force the Australian government to scale back its role in the war.

The battle builds

At 2:43 a.m. on August 17, a bombardment rocked Nui Dat. Three infantry companies were sent out to locate the communist forces but the rest of the day passed without significant incident. On August 18, 105 infantrymen from D Company of the Sixth Battalion, Royal Australian Regiment, were sent out on patrol, joined by three New Zealanders, forward observers from the artillery battery. The commander of the patrol was Major Harry Smith. His men were carrying light loads of ammunition—120 rounds per rifle and 1,000 rounds for each machine gun.

Coincidentally, August 18 was the date when two rock 'n' roll acts were due to give the first-ever concert at Nui Dat. Many in D Company were annoyed to miss out. As they left base at 11 a.m., they could hear the musicians rehearsing.